

Baby Asian Greens

CULTIVARS

- Mustard: Ruby Streaks, Garnet Giant.
- Kale: Red Russian, Siberian

INTENSIVE SPACING

- **6-row seeder** : 12 rows (2"- 6 cm) apart spaced every 1.5" (4 cm) on the row (C-M-T); Hole Size C, Middle pulley, Tight brush setting
- **Jang seeder** : 10 rows per bed spaced every 1,5" (4 cm) on the row X-24, 14F-9R, brush "0", ≠

FERTILIZATION

- Baby Asian greens will do great in beds that were previously amended with compost and fertilized with a mix of alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).
- Unlike arugula that really benefits from compost for nice second cuts, mustard and kale always seem to do fine without it (especially mustard).

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Sprinkler (more uniform than drip tape to cover the entire bed)

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Shallow (6"-24")
- Critical period: All stages, pre-harvest
- General: Frequent shallow water to maintain flavor and succulence and support rapid growth.

IMPLANTATION

Baby Asian greens are an important part of our mesclun mix production, but we also sell them individually, like arugula. For continuous supply, we seed each every week with an estimated 30% more than our weekly needs. We always plan for second cuts and, in some instances, a third one on the mustard.

In our program, baby Asian greens are seeded alongside turnips, radishes, and arugula, crops that will stay in the field for less than 45 days and that belong to the *brassicaceae* family. They therefore have the same fertilization and plant protection requirements.

EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- Seeder, scale, notepad and your seeds
- 30" bed prep rake
- Anti-insect netting (or row cover in the spring)

ITINERARY

- Remove tarps and clean out large debris. Use the rake if needed. *
- Uniformly apply amendments and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 1" (3 cm). Rake the bed carefully, removing all debris; soil clods, rocks, roots, etc. Beds need to be perfectly clean, levelled and firm for optimal usage of the 6-row seeder. If using the Jang seeder, beds should also be leved and firm, but need not to be so clean of rocks and debris
- Only seed when the bed surface is dry (If not, seeds will stick, and the seeder won't work properly). It's good practice to roll over the seed bed with the 6-row (without any seeds) in order to firm the seed bed and to make sure that it won't clog.
- Before seeding, take time to carefully adjust the 6-row seeder. To minimize uncertainty, we don't play with the whole size, nor do we adjust the depth of the planting. The brush, however, should be adjusted every time you seed.
- The gap under the brush (T–tight, N–normal, L–loose) should always be less than half the size of the seed being sown. For mustard and kale, we set it to T. To adjust the brush, turn it clockwise to open it more or counterclockwise to close it.

- To make sure that all six hoppers feed at the same rate, fill all of them with the exact same numbers of seeds. After seeding halfway in your first pass, adjust the brushes until all six are feeding at the same rate.
 - Cover with the anti-insect netting, install irrigation and water until the soil is deeply moistened.
- * If the previous crop is too well established, or if the bed is too messy, mow the crop as low as possible and harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). Add 1" (2.5 cm) of compost evenly spread on the whole width of the bed and transplant into compost following a no-till strategy.

WEEDING

- Like arugula, baby Asian greens cannot tolerate any weed pressure. Because we harvest quickly and efficiently using the greens harvester, there is no time to be picking through the crop for weeds.
- Tarping seed beds with black plastic for 2 weeks prior to seeding date is a good first start in diminishing weed pressure. Using the stale seedbed technique to force weeds to germinate before you plant is another good practice.
- In any case, cultivate using the flex tine weeder +/- 10 days after direct seeding the crop, and again 5 days later. Make at least 2 passes each time.

PLANT PROTECTION

- To protect the crop against flea beetles, immediately cover the bed with anti-insect netting (or row cover) after seeding.
- This practice is even more effective if the seedbed is irrigated before installing the netting as the water will chase away the flea beetles. The more tightly the sides are sealed, the better the results will be.

HARVEST

- Baby Asian greens are harvested when the leaves measure between 3" and 5" (8 and 13 cm) long.
- Use the quick-cut greens harvester with a new or very sharp blade.
- When using the tool, make sure that the blade doesn't touch the ground and ALWAYS pay attention not to have stems longer than 2' (5 cm).
- With a well-sharpened blade and a clean bed, one person should harvest at least 100 lbs/per hour.
- After the harvesting is done, pass over the cut area using a rake to remove the debris. Performing this operation ensures a second clean cut.

CONDITIONING

- Once the greens are harvested, the bins are brought to the packing station, placed on the cart and brought near the bubbler.
- Seeing as the mustard will be mixed in with the mesclun, refer to the mesclun procedures. If it's sold separately, follow the procedure for arugula.

STORING

- Baby Asian greens are stored in a cold room at 35 °F (2 °C) and should not be kept for more than 3 days before being sold.